immense intellect and vigour, of uncertain date but most probably active in the first quarter of the ninth century, and as much vilified within the Buddhist world as ‘the enemy of Buddhism’ as he is admired by Shaivas for his militant proselytising and for taking on the Buddhists on their own terms and showing them to be wanting.

Despite his physical handicap, Shankara is said to have personally led a *digvijaya* or ‘tour of conquest’ that took him as far north as Kashmir and Nepal, in the course of which he challenged through debate every opposing philosophy, most obviously Buddhism and Jainism. Having defeated all his opponents, he founded seminaries to promote his *advaita vedanta* teachings, built around the three elements of *shastra* (the scriptures), *yukti* (reason) and *anubhava* (experience). Of these seminaries, the most famous today are the four *matha*s (Hindu colleges or monasteries) established at the four corners of India, each headed by the best and brightest of his army of highly disciplined disciples, each of whom then established their own line of leaders, called Shankaracharyas. The first of the four *matha*s was set up at Sringeri,[7] in the hill-country of Karnataka, the other three being in Puri on the east coast, Dwaraka on the west coast and Badrinath in the Himalayas. Two of the four, Badrinath and Puri, are believed to have been places of Buddhist worship before they were Hindu.[8]

Shankara died at thirty-two years of age, but his movement spread the cult of the Shivalinga allied with *advaita* to every corner of the subcontinent and with such vigour that it has come to be seen by many today as the supreme expression of Hindu spirituality. That this fervour was accompanied by the active persecution of Buddhists, as claimed by the Dalit reformer Dr Ambedkar and others, is denied by Shankara’s present-day followers, who claim that Shankara achieved the expulsion of both Jains and Buddhists from the mainstream simply by defeating them in